Yitzhak Navon, the prime minister's aide and a future president of Israel. A few years before his death in 2015, Navon published his memories of the meeting. Ben-Gurion started by asking Karelitz how religious and secular Jews could live together in Israel. He responded with a parable from the Talmud. When two camels meet on a road, one carrying a load, the other unburdened, the latter must yield. "We, the religious Jews, are like the camel with the load. We carry a burden of hundreds of *mitzvot*," he explained. "You have to give way."

Ben-Gurion, the secular camel, tapped himself on the shoulder. "Do you think this camel has no load?" he asked, listing his responsibilities: working the land, absorbing hundreds of thousands of immigrants. "These aren't *mitzvot*?"

The conversation quickly devolved into a sort of chicken-and-egg argument. The prime minister mentioned the secular soldiers who guarded the borders and protected the religious Jews studying Torah, who would otherwise be "slaughtered". Again, he asked, weren't they performing a *mitzvah?* No, Karelitz replied, the soldiers were only there because of the devout young men in their *yeshivot*. Maybe so, Ben-Gurion answered, but what good is learning Torah if everyone gets killed? Karelitz wasn't worried. The Torah, he explained, was *etz chaim*, a "tree of life".

Then the *rebbe* complained about the widespread desecration of Shabbat in Israel, the secular youths who went to the beach instead of learning Torah. "You can't force them," Ben-Gurion said. "And if they don't go to the beach, you think they'll go to synagogue?" Again, Karelitz was unconcerned. "I believe that one day, everyone will keep the Sabbath and pray."

## *A monolith?*

The ultra-Orthodox are often presented as a monolith—a sea of men in uniform black coats. A visit to a *yeshiva* might reinforce this image: endless rows of young men wearing identical clothes, studying the same page of a religious text. But the community is quite diverse, with numerous divisions between sects and ethnicities. Some of them already share the burden: most *haredi* men do not work, but 46 per cent of them do, along with 71 per cent of women; about 2,000 men voluntarily enlist in the army each year. Overwhelmingly, however, they do not. The employment figure for men is